

Action Plan with defined milestones

Organization	Åland University of Applied Sciences
Responsible person	Rector
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Background

Åland University of Applied Sciences (AUAS) became an official signatory of the CoARA Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment (ARRA) on May 16, 2024. On July 7, 2024 AUAS joined the National Chapter of Finland. With this membership, we state our willingness to acknowledge a larger diversity in assessing research (outputs, methodologies, communication) and researchers (including various career paths), for the purpose of maximizing the quality and impact of research. More information on ARRA is found here: [The Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment](#).

Research at Åland University of Applied Sciences

The Finnish university system includes two major types of actors: research-driven universities and universities of applied sciences, the latter category to which AUAS belongs. This means that our RDI (research, development and innovation) work is applied to its nature, and also oriented towards interdisciplinarity, partnerships with various types of actors and translational research. Therefore, regional development, societal impact and a diversity of contributions and contributors are an integral part of the research done at AUAS. In consequence, several of the challenges brought about by the CoARA initiative play a less crucial role in our organization, as the initiative has arisen from challenges inherent in the academic research tradition. However, the CoARA process gives us the support to develop our RDI work alongside partner organizations as for underscoring the societal value of research work and in taking a more diverse approach to variations in assessment of research and researchers.

Åland University of Applied Sciences is one of the smallest universities in Finland with approximately 500 students in total, 75 employees and seven degree programs: business administration, navigation, hospitality management, engineering (marine, electrical and IT) and health caring sciences. Our open university engages about 2000 participants annually. Our RDI focus areas are accessible health, entrepreneurship of tomorrow and energy transition, in which digital tech solutions are integrated and developed. The four-fold perspective of sustainable development (cultural, economic, environmental and social) is crucial in all of our research and our work. We run about 10-15 RDI projects per year, most of these projects are externally financed and implemented in cooperation with private, public and academic partners in the Åland Islands, in mainland Finland or abroad.

Being a Finnish university of applied sciences, AUAS is committed to following the national regulatory framework on research as published by the Finnish National Board on Research Integrity TENK (www.tenk.fi/en) and the Declaration for Open Science and Research (www.avointiede.fi/en). We also follow the rules and regulations set by the Finnish Ministry of Education and Ålands regional government (Ålands landskapsregering).

Core Commitments and their implementation

Our Action Plan is for five years, beginning in mid 2024 and running until mid 2029. It covers three levels

- 1) **research**: by encouraging RDI projects to continuously adhere to the highest standards of quality with diverse methods of implementation, communication and output
- 2) **researchers**: by acknowledging that competence can derive from various backgrounds and take diverse forms
- 3) **research organization**: by participating in developing and transmitting ethical and responsible research for a sustainable development not only in our own organization, but also in the national and international networks that we participate in

The table below shows our roadmap for the implementation of the core commitments of the ARRA, inclusive of our defined milestones. In short, key actions by AUAS are:

- an increased flexibility of competence assessment in recruiting procedures for researcher positions or projects
- a new model of research output communication, which will include a more diverse array of communication tools
- a process change in recruitment where a researcher CV or gained competence can be demonstrated in a broader manner
- internal communication of ARRA and encouragement by staff to join CoARA working groups or social media
- external communication of our Action Plan

The table is based on a model suggested by CoARA and includes first three reflection points (starting phase), and then the ten commitments (operational action plan for 2024-2029). For each of these we express our roadmap and time plan.

Phase	Reflection /Commitment	Roadmap with aims and goals	Time plan
Starting phase	Reflect on your strategy and change approach	A CoARA steering group is established in our organization and our Action Plan is developed in cooperation with the key departments (research, communications, rectors and HR). We take part in CoARA working groups and transmit the principles through our organization in all our processes. Specific meetings to raise the awareness of the CoARA reform are to be arranged. All proposals for better practices that will emerge during the process will be handled by the steering group and discussed with the relevant departments.	2024-2025
	Involve your institutional community in the change process	The CoARA Communication Toolkit is shared with our Communications Department. The CoARA principles are shared with our Research, HR and Management Departments. Good practices are shared continuously in our everyday routines. We post information on our Action Plan both internally on our intranet and externally on our webpages. In informing the staff and colleagues about our membership and the idea of CoARA, we will suggest they follow some of the social media outlets - X (Twitter): @CoARAssessment - LinkedIn: Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment - Mastodon: @CoARAssessment - YouTube: @CoARAssessment - Hashtag: #ReformingRA	2024-2025
	Identify key challenges to address	Challenges include national and international regulations for eligibility criteria on specific researcher positions and other positions in our organization. These can be addressed only in the corresponding assemblies	2025-2028

		on managerial level.	
Operational action plan for years 2025-2030 CoARA Core Commitments listed 1-10	1. Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	Our organization engages predominantly in applied or practice-based research, in which recognition of outcomes is already very diverse. We plan to enable greater diversity in career paths and profiles through local co-operation in the ARENE national working groups. We launch a research seminar for our researchers for exchange of ideas and peer support for continuous improvement of research quality and diversity. This will be very trans-, inter- and multidisciplinary.	2025-2028
	2. Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	Our research assessment is currently predominantly based on peer review practices.	N/A
	3. Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publicationbased metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	The JIF and h-index are not of relevance in our organization, neither are other research assessment metrics.	N/A
	4. Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	We do not apply rankings of research organizations in research assessment.	N/A
	5. Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to	We include the CoARA commitment reform in the regular working hours of our key staff.	2024-
	6. Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	We develop our recruiting processes to include alternative criteria for assessment of competency. Also new ways of presenting CV, competence and background are welcomed.	2025-
	6.1 CRITERIA FOR UNITS		

	AND INSTITUTIONS With the direct involvement of research organisations and researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria for assessing research units and research performing organisations, while promoting interoperability 6.2 CRITERIA FOR PROJECTS AND RESEARCHERS With the direct involvement of researchers at all career stages, review and develop criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of research projects, research teams and researchers that are adapted to their context of application	Assessment of eligibility for positions is more flexible in order to advance career progression. Awareness of the CoARA criteria makes it even easier for us to continue including researchers at various career stages and project participants from various organizations in common endeavors.	
	7. Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use	In the recruitment processes related to research activities, we intend to make use of clearer communication on flexibility in competence assessment. This implies guidance for HR and recruitment groups, as well updates on professional profile eligibility criteria.	2025-
	8. Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition	By taking part in the CoARA National Chapter/Finland and engaging in relevant working groups across our organization, we exchange practices and foster exchange of good practices nationally and internationally.	2024-
	9. Communicate progress made on adherence to the Principles and implementation of the Commitments	Internal communication on our progress takes place during special seminars and meetings, as well as on our intranet. External communication takes place on our website.	2025-2028
	10. Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for	Regular communication across departments in our organization and within the internal steering group facilitates (re)evaluation of our Action Plan. We intend to evaluate our research by analyzing what type of	2029

	evidence gathering and research	projects have been initiated in our organization. This is the responsibility of our RDI department. Data will openly be available when possible and all research will follow the principles of open publications. We will launch a new model of communication of our RDI initiatives for enhancing knowledge exchange and societal impact.	
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This Action Plan is to be (re)evaluated yearly and revised when needed. A new plan will be posted on the CoARA website within 5 years, i.e. 2029.